



Kaizen

Started in Japan, kaizen is a system of continuous improvement that involves all employees. From senior managers to people on the shop floor, everyone is encouraged to suggest improvements day to day.

How it works

The kaizen philosophy is “to do it better, make it better, improve it even if it isn’t broken, because if we don’t, we can’t compete with those who do.” Kaizen is rarely about ideas for major change but has more to do with ongoing, systematic, incremental improvement. A relentless attempt to eliminate unnecessary activities, delay, or waste (*muda*), Kaizen starts with setting high

standards and then looking for ways to continually improve those standards. It is supported by a framework of training, communication, and supervision, and results in improved efficiency, productivity, quality, lead time, and customer loyalty.

Creating good change

Kaizen events are implemented through a cycle of activity, known as plan, do, check, act. Central to kaizen are quality, ongoing effort, involvement of every employee as part of their daily work, willingness to change, and communication.

BETTER AND BETTER

Kaizen was created in Japan after World War II. It comes from the Japanese words *kai*, which means “change” or “to correct,” and *zen*, which means “good.” Companies such as Toyota and Canon have seen significant improvements by involving their employees in recommendations for change.

KAI

ZEN

改善

CHANGE

GOOD

70
suggestions per
employee were
implemented at
Toyota in 1983



Innovate

Innovate—find and implement better ways to meet requirements and increase productivity.

Quality

Effort

Gauge

Gauge measurements against required standards.